power, and that Argentina's national honor was at stake in establishing sovereignty over them.

As we spoke, Argentina's invasion preparations were already under way. The next morning, about one thousand Argentinean troops landed on the Falklands, whose total population was less than two thousand people, most of them of British ancestry. Within a few days, a British Royal Navy armada had steamed toward the Falklands and both sides asked for our help should the dispute come to war.

The leaders of Argentina's military junta were trying to seize the remote islands to save their government. Their domestic political position was precarious because of mounting economic troubles and rumors of grave human-rights abuses in Argentina. Galtieri thought we would side with Argentina because we were neighbors in the Americas and because we had requested the junta's help in fighting Communism in the hemisphere. It was true that I had placed a high priority on improving relations with our Latin neighbors, and Argentina was one of the countries where we had been working hardest to bring about democratic reforms. But the junta misjudged not only Margaret Thatcher's will but the strength of our ties to England and our opposition to armed aggression wherever it occurred, even on the obscure shores of a few rocky islands in the South Atlantic.

Despite some resistance from Jeane Kirkpatrick, our UN representative, who disagreed with our position, we let the junta know privately that, while we would provide military help to neither adversary, our sympathies were on the British side. We were staunch allies of the United Kingdom and supported its right to defend its colony. We also assured Margaret Thatcher that we were fully behind Britain. Publicly, however, I decided it was wisest to mute our reaction while extending the good offices of the United